

all the games, no matter how many hours we put in (and many hours we did), we never once saw a game skip, or even come close to doing so. Ultimately, it's like gaming on a top-of-the-line PC—one whose graphics card will cost you considerably more than the Xbox itself. Whether this is good or bad really depends on how much else you do on a PC besides gaming.

All this blistering performance does come at a price, if the amount of hot air that spews from the vents at the back is any indication. Heating components are hardly surprising, but before you reach for your wallet, you need to make sure you choose the space for your new love with heat dissipation in mind. Don't get any crazy ideas into your head—like confining it in its own cabinet; all the complaints we heard about the 360 being unstable more often than not stemmed from nitwits who kept it locked in a box and on all day.



The whole kit and kaboodle—the Xbox 360 System will contain all this, sans the game titles

Not that you should waste your 360 playing movies, but it makes for a pretty competent DVD player as well. Navigating the various menus using the controller feels quite strange, but not too hard to get used to. The Xbox 360 system will come with a media remote included for your convenience as well.

Little Things Matter

We'd rather have skipped the little bells and whistles, but small though they are, they can hardly be ignored. The first to earn the favour of our lazy behinds is the fact that you can shut down the console from the controller itself. After a hard day's gaming, the last thing you want to waste your time doing is walking over to the box and hitting the button—just shut it down from the comfort of your chair and doze off!

Another noteworthy thing is the customisation the Xbox dashboard gives you based on the user profile you create. It lets you select themes, personalise your Xbox settings, and keep track of your progress and achievements in each game you play.

Launch Pad

When the Xbox 360 launches during the pre-Diwali season, it will be available in two flavours—the no-frills Core System and the Xbox 360 System.

The Core System will come with the Console, a Wired Controller and a Composite AV Cable—you'll have to spring for the HD AV cable if you want hi-def joy. Add one leading game title to this and the lot will set you back an estimated Rs 19,990.

The Xbox 360 System (the one we got for testing) comes with the Console (with a shiny Premium Chrome Finish, even), a 20 GB hard drive, a wireless controller, a Universal Media Remote for when you whip out the popcorn and DVDs, a Component HD AV cable, and an Ethernet cable. All this and prolonged joy for the expected price of Rs 23,990.

Twenty titles will accompany the launch. The list isn't final yet, but we're willing to bet it will include *Perfect Dark: Zero*—the title that will sell the console while we wait for *Halo 3* to hit the scene.

As we write this, we have no information on whether Xbox Live will launch at the same time as the 360: watch this space for the dope as it happens. Xbox Live is a key part of the 360's success, and it would be a shame to miss out on it, especially with nearly all games being "Live-aware" and giving you the ability to socialise with (or smash the dickens out of) players all over the world.

In Toto

We're completely blown away by the Xbox 360 (as if we didn't expect it)—tremendous performance, a brilliant controller, and high-definition eye-candy that will make you shun gaming on a regular TV.

What concerns us is the money that you'll be shelling out—not just the cost of console itself: you'll eventually need to spring for an HDTV and an elaborate surround sound system, not to mention the probable bomb (Indian prices for titles haven't been set yet) that each title is going to set you back by.

The lack of Xbox Live is also quite the disappointment, and we do wish to see it soon after the launch, if not at launch time itself. If the launch collection is the same as those in the international launches, there's little to look forward to, but since many more titles have been released since then, we might be in for a very enticing list—we'll keep you informed as it unfolds.

Today, being able to afford the 360 and not going ahead and buying it seems unthinkable, but that might change with the launch of the PS3. Even so, you won't be sorry coughing up for this baby. ■

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